



**U.S. Citizenship
and Immigration
Services**

Control Number: COW2026000731

May 12, 2026

Michael Wriston
Via Digital Request

Dear Michael Wriston:

We received your request for information relating to:

"Pursuant to the Freedom of Information Act, 5 U.S.C. § 552, I request records sufficient to describe the nature, purpose, and operational use of the tool known as "VOWS" (Vetting of Wedding-Based Schemes), reportedly developed or supported by Palantir Technologies and used by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. This request is limited to records created or updated from January 1, 2025 to the present. Specifically, I request the following categories of records: 1. System descriptions, concept of operations documents, or equivalent materials that describe what VOWS is and how it is used by USCIS personnel. 2. Privacy Impact Assessments, System of Records Notices, or internal privacy or civil liberties assessments specific to VOWS. 3. Policies, guidance, or standard operating procedures governing reliance on VOWS outputs in adjudicative or investigative decision-making. This request does not seek source code, algorithms, model weights, or sensitive technical vulnerabilities. If any portion of the requested records is exempt from disclosure, please release all reasonably segregable non-exempt material. Fee Waiver: I request a waiver of all search, review, and duplication fees pursuant to 5 U.S.C. § 552(a)(4)(A)(iii). Disclosure of the requested information is in the public interest because it is likely to contribute significantly to public understanding of the operations and activities of the government and is not primarily in my commercial interest. The requested records concern the use of an automated or data-driven vetting tool in immigration adjudications, an area implicating due process, privacy, and civil liberties. There is substantial public interest in understanding how such tools are deployed, what safeguards govern their use, and the extent to which their outputs may influence government decision-making. Disclosure of these records will contribute meaningfully to public understanding by shedding light on USCIS's policies and practices regarding algorithmic or analytic systems used in marriage-based immigration contexts—information that is not otherwise publicly available in sufficient detail. I intend to analyze and disseminate any information received through reporting and public-interest research, making the results available to a broad audience. I have no commercial interest in the requested information. If you determine that a fee waiver is not appropriate, please notify me in advance if estimated fees are expected to exceed \$25. If you have any questions regarding this request or believe it can be further narrowed to expedite processing, please contact me."

A thorough search was conducted by USCIS but no records relating to your request were located.

You have the right to file an administrative appeal within 90 days of the date of this letter. By filing an appeal, you preserve your rights under FOIA and give the agency a chance to review and reconsider your request and the agency's decision. You may file an administrative FOIA appeal electronically to USCIS through your online portal by selecting Appeal in the Actions drop down window. You may also file an administrative FOIA appeal to USCIS at: USCIS FOIA/PA Appeals Office, 150 Space Center Loop, Suite 500, Lee's Summit, MO 64064-2139. Both the letter and the envelope should be clearly marked "Freedom of Information Act Appeal."

If you would like to discuss our response before filing an appeal to attempt to resolve your dispute without going through the appeals process, you may contact our USCIS FOIA Public Liaison by email at FOIAPAQuestions@uscis.dhs.gov.

A USCIS FOIA Public Liaison is an agency official to whom FOIA requesters can raise concerns about the service the requester has received from the agency's FOIA Office. USCIS FOIA Public Liaisons are responsible for assisting in reducing delays, increasing transparency, and understanding of the status of requests, and assisting in the resolution of disputes.

If you are unable to resolve your FOIA dispute through our USCIS FOIA Public Liaison, you may contact the Office of Government Information Services (OGIS) at the National Archives and Records Administration to inquire about the FOIA mediation services they offer. The contact information for OGIS is Office of Government Information Services, National Archives and Records Administration, 8601 Adelphi Road-OGIS, College Park, Maryland 20740-6001; email ogis@nara.gov; telephone 202-741-5770; toll free 877-684-6448; or facsimile 202-741-5769.

How to Submit Questions or Changes

Questions concerning this FOIA/PA request may be emailed to FOIAPAQuestions@uscis.dhs.gov. All FOIA/PA related requests, including address changes, must be submitted in writing, and signed by the requester. Please include the control number listed above on all correspondence with this office. For more information regarding the USCIS FOIA Program, please visit uscis.gov/foia. If you email us and want to provide personal information (such as A-number, social security number or passport number) so we can better assist you, please include it in the body of your email and not in the subject line. Including personal information in the subject line may violate our privacy guidelines.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink that reads "Jarrod T Panter". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Jarrod" being more prominent than the last name "Panter".

Jarrod T Panter

Acting Chief FOIA Officer

Freedom of Information Act & Privacy Act Unit